explained for MAME / MESS above, ROM files are contents of a ROM chip dumped into a file.

They are even more significant when it comes to older cartridge-based consoles, since these cartridges essentially contained ROM chips storing the game data. The ROM files you will find online are extracted from these cartridges and put in files by people with the knowhow.

For more modern systems such as the PlayStation 2, ROMs refer to the OS stored in a ROM chip on those systems since the game data comes on disks — which are technically ROM disks but we'll let that slide for now. The PlayStation 2 emulator emulates the hardware of the PlayStation, it does not come with the OS the PlayStation 2 runs, and that is a necessity if you want to play PlaySation 2 games. Again this is a legally and morally grey issue.

And now to our regularly scheduled booklet. Let's start with the big one, Nintendo.

Nintendo

Nearly all of Nintendo's consoles except for the most recent can be emulated with ease these days. There a many emulators for Nintendo that support multiple of their consoles.

There is one recent emulator called higan that is quite important since it not only support multiple Nintendo systems, such as the NES, SNES, Game Boy, Game Boy Color, Game Boy Advance etc but it also has a focus on accurate emulation, to the extent that it will emulate bugs in the system as well rather than correct for them. That said higan is current a pretty well performing emulator has separate performance and accuracy modes.

For pure NES emulation JNES — not to be confused with JSNES which runs in the browser — is a great NES emulator that is also available for Android. FCEUX is another NES focused emulator. And for pure SNES emulation there is Snes9x.

Final Fantasy VI for the SNES running on Windows via Snes9X.

Next we come to the Nintendo 64. Currently the emulators that you are looking for are Mupen-64Plus and Project64. Both work well, but Mupen64Plus has the